OFF THE GRID

World Design & Directorial Work

World Overview

When I joined Off the Grid, there was no wholesale World Design and no World Director. Beyond two partially implemented locations (Little Kyiv and Saltie), everything else needed to be created from scratch. I retrofitted and designed the entire World to serve both short-term delivery goals AND future expansion of the whole island - with clear, consistent Landscape, Connections, Narrative, and Gameplay.

1. Landscape Design

Terrain & Biomes

Established a Granitic Island terrain type to support the required Tropical biome with the rounded, massive rocks Art Direction demanded. After extensive iteration and research, I selected Fatu Hiva from French Polynesia as the reference, giving us maximum flexibility for both artistic and technical needs.

Team & Collaboration

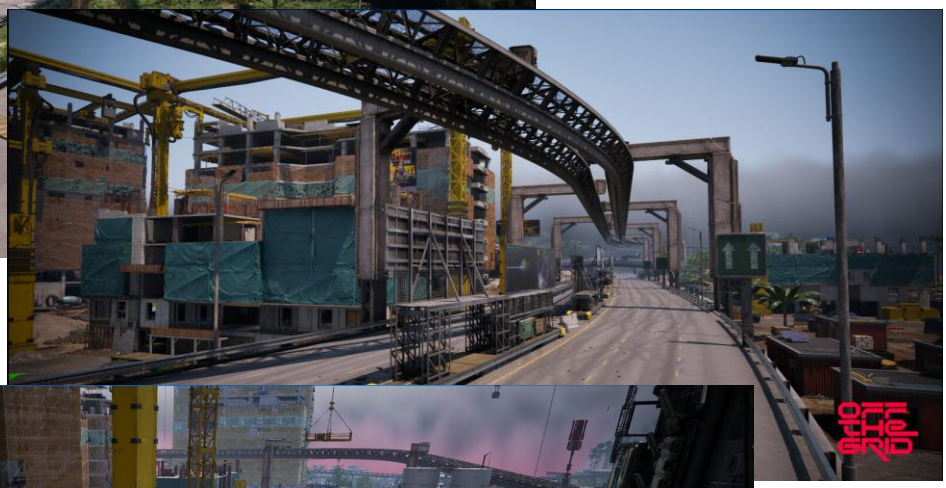
Managed and directed Ilya Marechal and Charlene Rose, working alongside Tech Art to split the massive scope into manageable pieces: Terrain (base geography and heightmaps), Rocks (focal geological features), and Foliage (vegetation and plant life). Each domain presented the core conflict of Composition/Readability versus Reality adherence, and each required extensive iteration before the final result shipped.

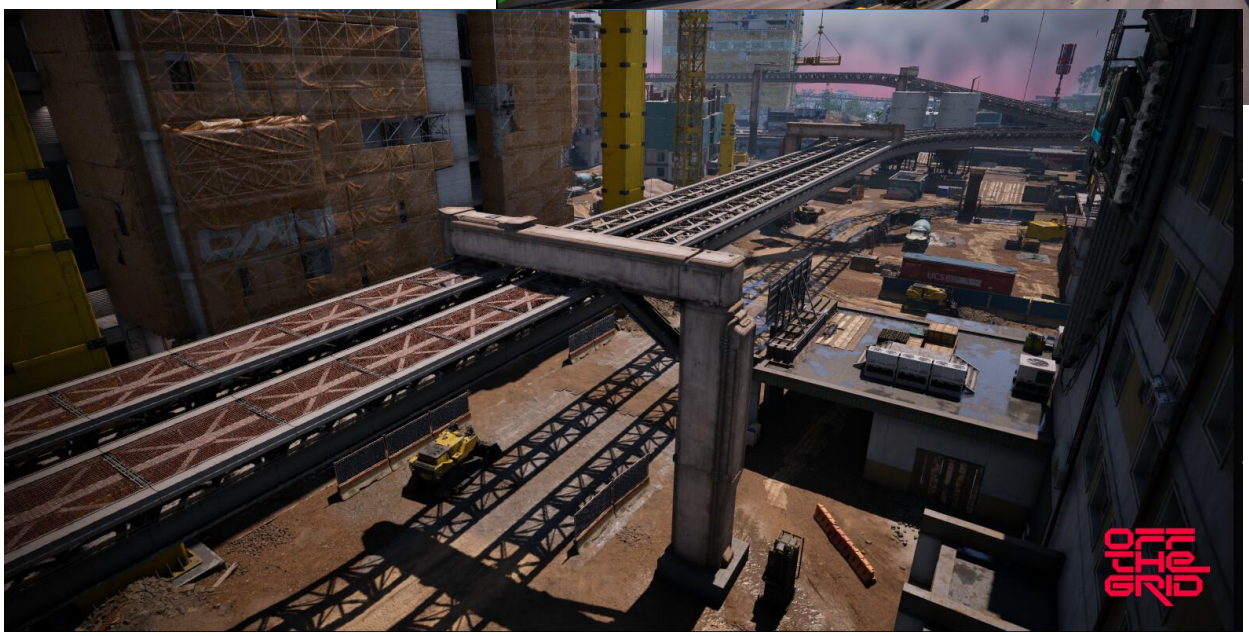
2. Road System

Worked directly with Vitaliy Avdyeyev (my team) and Georgi Hristov (Tech Art) to design and implement the entire Road Structure through a Houdini tool. This was foundational infrastructure for the entire game.

Key Features:

- Designed for vehicle mechanics with realism, inter-connectedness, and believability
- Enabled fast, fun player relocation while supporting the expansive location count we planned
- Built in easy expansion capability for future development
- Also designed and implemented the Monorail Train system as a supplementary fast-travel layer





3. New Location Design

Teardrop Island

When I joined, the island's locations existed as disconnected ideas with no cohesive structure. I stepped in as World Director and created a unified design language that showed the natural progression of civilization across the island - each region building on the last, with clear narrative and gameplay purpose.

BETA Region Locations:

Little Kyiv - Main city, central hub

Saltie - Desalination plant supplying fresh water to island

Midtown Harbour - Main entrance point

Stork City - New development, middle-to-high income housing

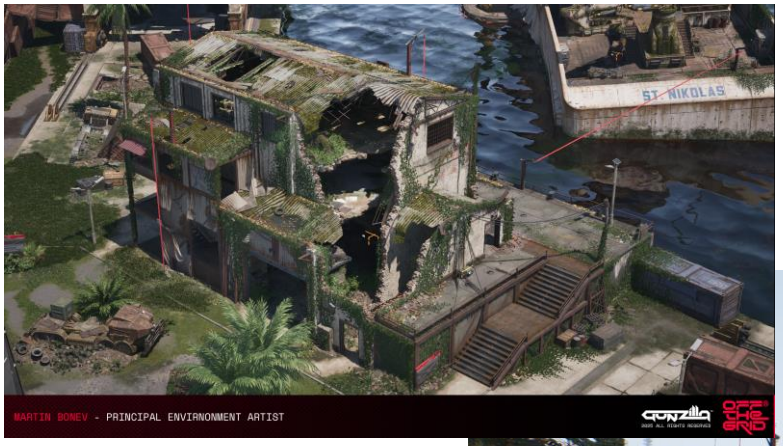
Ocio - Billionaires' seaside resort

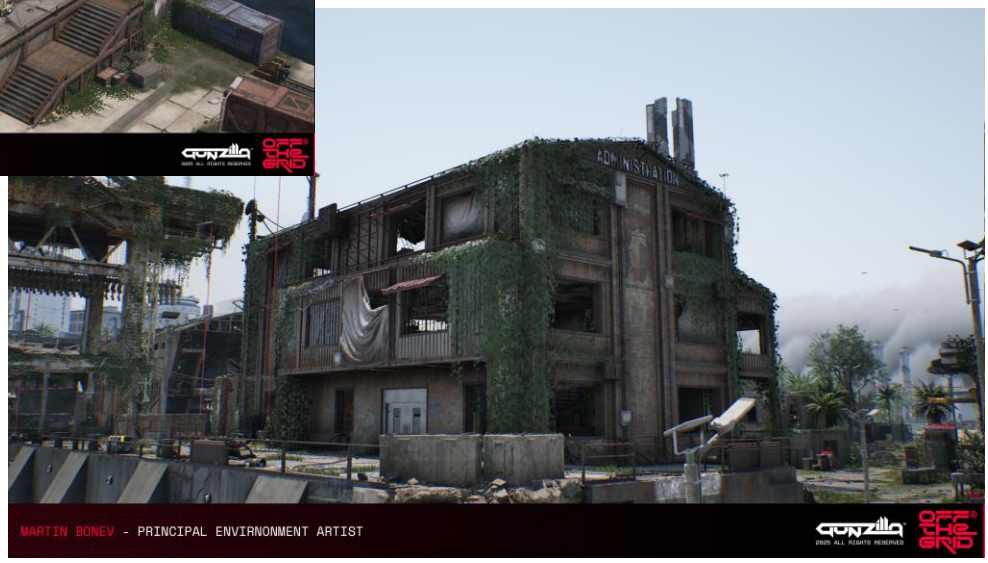
Planned (Gamma & Omega): Military base, trash burning facility, American-style town with massive Mall, ship breaking beach.

Midtown Harbour – Port of Entry

The last location shipped, it reflects the full optimization of our workflows. Working with Barbod Nili, we established clear separation between the two main zones – the public Harbour and the Industrial Harbour.

Each zone has distinct Theme, Purpose, and Gameplay with minimal bleed between them. This was the culmination of everything we learned building the earlier locations.





Ocio Resort

This location was finishing blockout when I joined but required major intervention to become the premium destination the game needed.

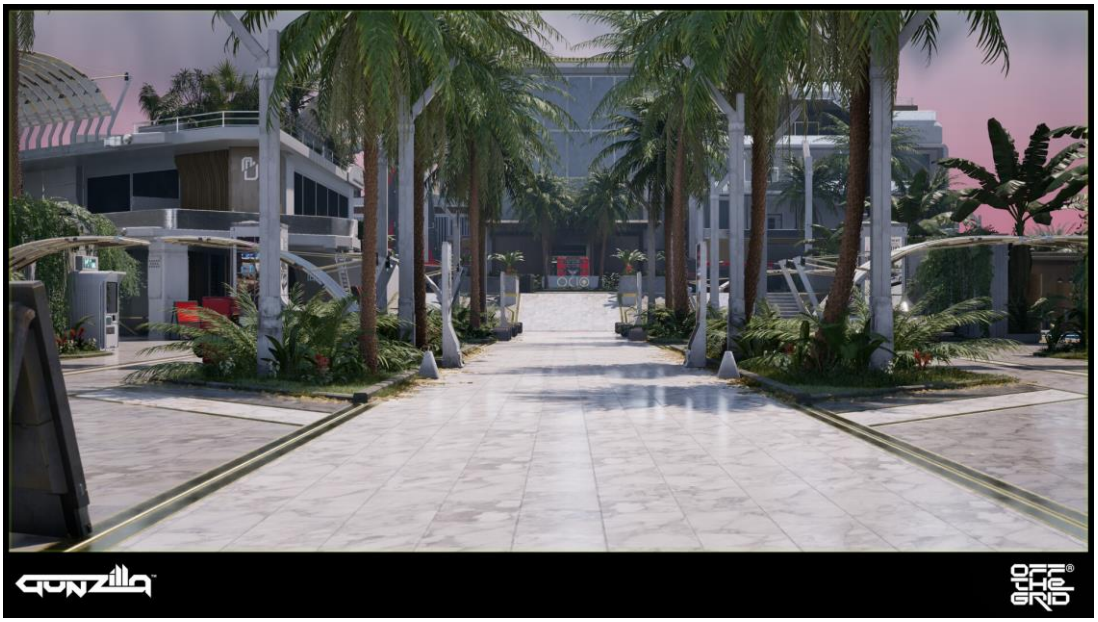
My Approach:

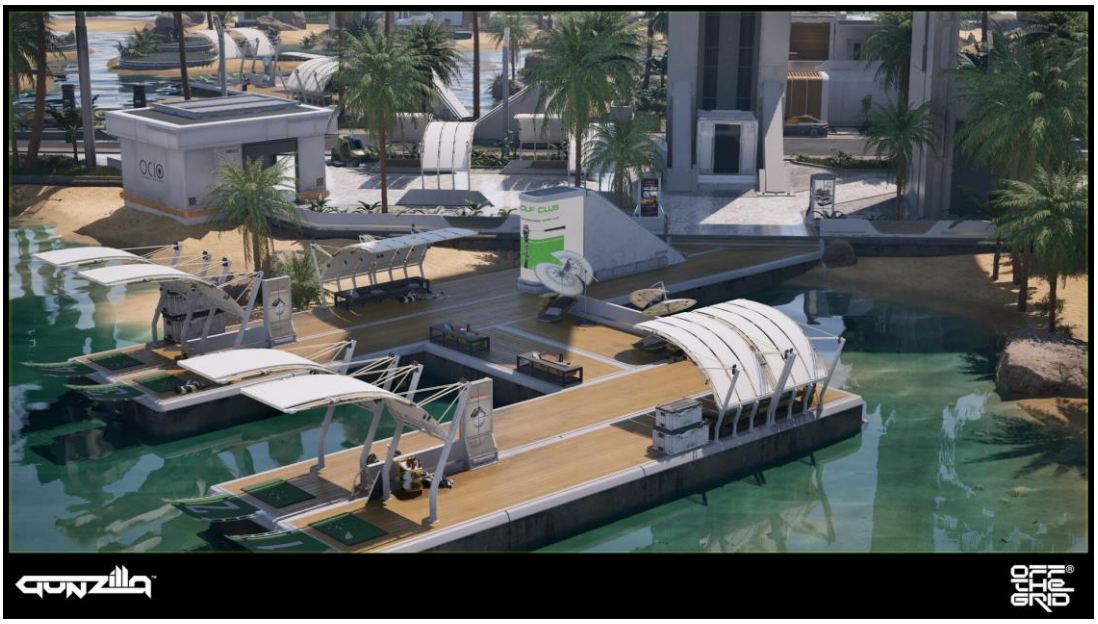
1. **Design Retention & Retrofitting** - Rather than scrapping what existed, I evaluated every element for gameplay value. The core layout worked; the issue was Art constraints hadn't been met and Art Direction kept shifting toward a more luxurious aesthetic. I systematically retrofitted Art decisions back into the gameplay spaces, ensuring fun remained the priority even as visuals evolved.

2. **Anchor Points & Wayfinding** - After the Art rework, I ran player perception tests. Results showed Ocio was getting lost in the landscape-players couldn't orient themselves. I made the critical decision to add 2 massive Towers as visual landmarks, creating instant wayfinding without gameplay interruption.

3. **Strategic Relocation** - In the original world design, Ocio was isolated, way too far from every other location to feel part of the island's economy. Halfway through Whiteboxing, I identified this as critical. I proposed and got Creative approval to move Ocio approximately 500m closer to Stork City. This was a significant call that required reworking adjacent areas, but it improved playability by 100%.

Result: The relocation created the Ocio Dam in the negative space, thus turning a constraint into a new location that served the world's water infrastructure narrative.





4. Micro-Locations

When the Art team's estimates came in significantly over scope for the main locations, I immediately pivoted strategy. Rather than let the shortfall slow down world completion, I built a plan that leveraged our Level Design team's strengths by using existing assets and kits to create iconic, cohesive spaces that still felt hand-crafted.

Ocio Dam

My Role: Designed the concept and directed Charlene Rose through implementation.

Concept: I established the thematic requirement: the dam existed to pump fresh water to Ocio. This was more than a gameplay node, it was infrastructure that made the world's resource logic believable. Every design decision flowed from that premise.

Execution: Charlene led the build while I provided direct, consistent feedback on everything from the shape of the intake structures to the scale of the overflow channels. I reviewed each stage of whiteboxing, pushing back when geometry felt mechanical rather than organic. The result is a location that reads as natural terrain with purpose rather than game architecture forced into a landscape.

Highway Compounds

My Role: Briefed Mark Fry and defined the design parameters.

Concept: The island's Military presence needed physical representation beyond bases, checkpoint hubs that controlled flow between major locations. These compounds needed to function as small islands of utility where players could resupply and redeploy without breaking immersion.

Challenges I Solved:

Scope Management - These locations sat in areas already high in detail. Over-designing would create visual noise; under-designing would make them feel empty. I had to find the precise balance and ensure performance was respected.

Believability - The Military presence had to feel consequential. Checkpoints needed appropriate equipment and layout to justify their narrative existence.

Gameplay Realism - Players needed to move through quickly while still feeling the checkpoint's purpose.

I gave Mark Fry clear guidance: minimal footprint, maximum function, equipment that told the right story. The compound layouts went through several iterations to hit the right balance of visual density versus gameplay space.

Key Achievements

- Built World Design from scratch. No framework existed; I created one that scaled and allowed us to ship on time and to a high quality.
- Managed 14+ team members – directed the Level Design team across multiple workstreams.
- Designed expandable systems. The road, monorail, and location systems built for growth over a huge, expanding world.
- Balanced Art constraints with Gameplay. Made tough calls (Ocio towers, relocation) that preserved both visual and functional quality.
- Optimized workflows and Midtown Harbour's quality reflects lessons learned across all previous locations.